

Frank never did muster the courage to share his financial situation with his girlfriend. He was paralyzed into inaction by his fear of her leaving him. The counselor realized her advice had not been heeded when Frank came in for another credit counseling session a year later after filing bankruptcy.

Unable to hide his bankruptcy from Ruth, she ended up finding out what he had been working so hard to hide. Rather than leave him, Ruth was actually sitting beside him in the counseling session. As they went over their budget with the counselor, Ruth offered to cut down or eliminate some of her expenses. She had always spent a lot of money because Frank had never even hinted she should stop. Ruth assumed Frank was one of the internet millionaires and he in no way said anything to dispel that image. Instead of abandoning Frank, she became his advocate and willingly gave back the support he had given her. Unfortunately, it took an act as traumatic as a bankruptcy for Frank to learn the true depth of his girlfriend's love.

It is helpful to remember that each individual has a different style in how they deal with money. By overcoming the inability to communicate about money, much of the bitterness, anger, betrayal, and lack of trust can be eliminated, and money will hopefully not be the reason if you choose to part.

Frank approached money as believing that "Rich means happy." If he was not rich, how could he be happy? Frank's fears were based on his perception of what his girlfriend would do if he curtailed her spending. Studies have shown that over 90 percent of what we worry about never comes to be. If Frank had mustered up the courage to be honest with his girlfriend about their financial situation, he would have found out that having "lots of money" was not that important of a priority for her. Then Frank would have been able to explain his financial limitations and the debt load would not have gotten out of control in the first place.

